

Dizziness or Light-Headedness When Standing Up

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In some people, particularly older adults, blood pressure drops excessively when they sit or stand up (a condition called orthostatic or postural hypotension). Symptoms of faintness, light-headedness, dizziness, confusion, or blurred vision occur within seconds to a few minutes of standing (particularly after lying in bed or sitting for a long time) and resolve rapidly when the person lies down. However, some people fall, faint, or very rarely have a brief seizure. Symptoms are often more common and worse after people exercise, have consumed alcohol and/or a heavy meal, or are deficient in fluids ([dehydration](#)).

Some younger people experience similar symptoms upon standing but without having a drop in blood pressure. Often, their heart rate increases (tachycardia) more than normal upon standing, so this condition is called postural orthostatic tachycardia syndrome (POTS). The reason why such people feel dizzy despite having normal blood pressure is not clear.

Causes of Dizziness or Light-Headedness When Standing Up

Dizziness or light-headedness when standing up occurs as a result of abnormal blood pressure regulation. Normally, when people stand, gravity causes blood to pool in the veins of the legs and trunk. This pooling lowers the blood pressure and the amount of blood the heart pumps to the brain. Low blood flow to the brain causes the dizziness and other symptoms. To compensate, the nervous system quickly increases the heart rate and constricts blood vessels, which rapidly returns blood pressure to normal before symptoms can develop. The part of the nervous system responsible for this compensation is the [autonomic nervous system](#).

Many disorders can cause problems with blood pressure regulation and lead to dizziness when standing up. Categories of causes include

- Malfunction of the autonomic nervous system due to disorders or medications
- Decreased ability of the heart to pump blood
- Decreased blood volume (hypovolemia)
- Faulty hormonal responses

Causes differ depending on whether symptoms are new or have been present for some time.

Common causes

The most common causes of **new** dizziness when standing up include

- Decreased blood volume (as may result from dehydration or blood loss)
- Medications
- Prolonged bed rest
- An underactive adrenal gland ([adrenal insufficiency](#))

The most common causes of dizziness when standing up that has been present for a **long time (chronic)** include

- Age-related changes in blood pressure regulation
- Medications
- Malfunction of the autonomic nervous system

Evaluation of Dizziness or Light-headedness When Standing Up

People who become dizzy or light-headed when standing up often recover quickly when they sit down and then slowly stand again. However, it is usually important to determine what is causing the dizziness. The following information can help people decide when to see a doctor and help them know what to expect during the evaluation.

Warning signs

In people who become dizzy or light-headed when standing up, certain symptoms and characteristics are cause for concern. They include

- Blood in the stool or black, tarry stool
- Nervous system symptoms such as difficulty walking and/or poor coordination or balance
- Falling or fainting (passing out)
- Chest pain or discomfort

When to see a doctor

People who have warning signs should seek emergency department care right away. Other people who have frequent or ongoing episodes of dizziness upon standing should see a doctor as soon as possible. People who have only an occasional episode of dizziness upon standing should call their doctor. The doctor will decide whether and how quickly to see the person depending on the other symptoms and medical history.

What the doctor does

The doctor first asks questions about the person's symptoms and medical history. Doctors then do a physical examination. What they find during the history and physical examination often suggests a cause of the dizziness and the tests that may need to be done.

Doctors ask

- How long the dizziness has been occurring
- Whether the person has fainted or fallen during an episode of dizziness
- Whether the person has experienced conditions that are known to cause dizziness (such as bed rest or fluid loss)
- Whether the person has a disorder (such as [diabetes](#), [Parkinson disease](#), or a cancer) that may cause dizziness
- Whether the person is taking a medication (for example, an antihypertensive) that may cause dizziness

The doctor then does a physical examination. The person lies down for 5 minutes, and then the doctor measures the blood pressure and heart rate. Blood pressure and heart rate are measured again after the person stands or sits up for 1 minute and again after standing or sitting for 3 minutes. The doctor may do a digital rectal examination to see whether the person might have some bleeding in the digestive

tract. A neurologic examination to test strength, sensation, reflexes, balance, and gait is important.

The most common causes of sudden dizziness—medications, bed rest, and decreased blood volume—are usually obvious. In people with long-term symptoms, findings such as movement problems may indicate [Parkinson disease](#). Numbness, tingling, or weakness may indicate a nervous system disorder.



Some Causes and Features of Dizziness or Light-Headedness When Standing Up

Cause	Common Features*	Tests
Central nervous system† disorders		
Multiple system atrophy	Muscle stiffness	A doctor's examination Sometimes MRI
	Slow, shaky movements	
	Loss of coordination and/or balance	
	Incontinence or inability to urinate	
Parkinson disease	Muscle stiffness	Only a doctor's examination
	Tremor	
	Slow, shaky movements and a shuffling gait	
	Difficulty walking	
Strokes if several have occurred	In people who are known to have had strokes	Only a doctor's examination
Spinal cord disorders		
Syphilis that affects the spinal cord (tabes dorsalis)	Intense, stabbing pains in the legs that come and go	Blood tests and sometimes a spinal tap (to obtain cerebrospinal fluid) to check for syphilis
	Unsteady walking	
	Decreased sensation in the legs and numbness or tingling	
Tumors	Back pain	MRI
	Muscle weakness and decreased sensation in the legs	



MSD
dorsalis)

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